DAN XU

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PROFILE SUMMARY

Almost 6 years in **international sales strategy, distributor and key account management** for **beauty, personal care and FMCG brands** across Japan, China and Asia. At **Nomura (Tier 1 Japan Consulting firm)** I built the **market analyses, forecasts and entry strategies** that Japanese manufacturers used to decide **which new markets, channels and partners** to back. At **Rakuten (No.1 Japan EC)** I ran the execution: won an **exclusive distribution mandate**, managed **8 Japanese brand key accounts** in **long-term partnerships** and reached **132% of GMV and gross-profit targets**. Experienced in **contract negotiation**, **partner performance reviews** and **sales reporting** for brand headquarters. Fluent English, Japanese (JLPT N1), Mandarin native, German B2 (zertifiziert). Having **lived, worked and travelled across Asia, Europe and the Americas**, including **volunteering in South America**, I build trust quickly with partners from different cultures. Based in **Düsseldorf**, open to roles across Germany and Europe and to international travel.

SKILLS

- **International sales strategy**: market potential, new regions, entry models, channel priorities
- **Distributor management**: partner selection, onboarding, contracts, performance reviews
- **Key account management**: long-term partnerships, business reviews, negotiation
- **Market analyses and reporting**: forecasts, competitor benchmarks, KPI reports for leadership
- **Cosmetics, FMCG and e-commerce**: assortment, pricing, promotions, margin and volume targets
- **Cross-cultural stakeholder management**: brand HQ and partner alignment, local market immersion
- Tools: Excel, PowerPoint, KPI dashboards, AI tools (Claude/Cursor)

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Nomura Research Institute Shanghai Limited · Mar 2023 – Dec 2024

Strategy Consultant

- Built **market analyses, forecasts and strategy reports** for beauty, personal care and FMCG clients.
- Turned the analysis into **market entry and channel recommendations** adopted by client leadership.

Selected Projects

- **Global Beauty Manufacturer (Japan HQ): Market Review & Entry Strategy**
  - As **project leader**, ran **half-yearly reviews** of consumer, channel and platform trends by **price segment**.
  - Benchmarked **competitors and late-entrant foreign brands' entry models**: cross-border e-commerce first, then **distributors and general trade**, exclusive retailers or own flagships.
  - Recommended **product, positioning, channel split and supply route** (import vs local production) for each brand and presented the strategy to **Japan HQ leadership** every six months.
- **Global Household & Personal Care Manufacturer (Japan HQ): Market Entry & Distributor Routes (PM)**
  - As **project manager**, rated 20+ product concepts on **market potential**, growth and channel fit.
  - Mapped **distributor zones and trade flows** (drugstore, specialty, convenience) for **partner selection**.
  - Narrowed to **~10 SKUs** with pricing and route plans, adopted into the client's **sales roadmap**.

Rakuten Group (Shanghai) · Mar 2021 – Mar 2023

Market Entry Consultant & Market Expansion Manager

- Ran **day-to-day sales and partner management** for 8 Japanese consumer and personal care brands.
- Acted as the **bridge between Japanese brand HQ and local partners** on terms, priorities and execution.

- Developed **partnerships end to end**: competitive bids, onboarding, joint planning and growth proposals.

Selected Projects

- **New Distribution Partner: Exclusive Mandate Won in First 6 Months, Japanese Consumer Brand**
  - As **project lead**, took on a **competitive bid** for a Japanese hair care brand losing sales to **channel price disorder** and new entrants; built its **China strategy** from market, consumer and competitor analysis.
  - Proposed **unified retail and sell-in price control** with a third-party price monitor, built a **3-year P&L and risk plan** with sales and legal, and **negotiated terms with Japan HQ**.
  - Won a **long-term exclusive mandate** against two agencies and led onboarding to the **first sell-in**.
- **Partnership Development & Key Account Management: 8 Japanese Brand Principals**
  - Built a **joint business plan and sales forecast** with each brand HQ and ran **quarterly reviews**.
  - Proposed **new marketing campaigns and product launches** to brand HQs from **consumer insights, price bands and competitor moves**, timed to the 618 and Double 11 peaks to drive **market growth**.
  - Set **pricing guardrails and promotion caps** after tracing margin loss to channel price gaps.
  - Kept **long-term partnerships** with all 8 brands and reached **132% of GMV and gross-profit targets**.
- **New Sales Channel: Cross-Border Social Commerce Launch**
  - Built the **business case from zero** (channel economics, competitors, partners) and won approval.
  - Designed a **20+ step operating model** covering trade flow, logistics, settlement and inventory risk.
  - Launched with three brands; the first brand delivered **~20% sales growth** versus the prior year.

YRGLM Inc. (Tokyo) · Apr 2019 – Mar 2021

Marketing Analyst & Business Development Specialist

- Joined as the **first foreign sales hire** and rotated through **BD, marketing analysis and inside sales**.
- Analysed **campaign, channel and funnel data** for e-commerce clients, supporting **110% YoY revenue**.
- Presented **performance reports and recommendations** in Japanese to client teams.

Selected Projects

- **Proposal-Based Sales: Digital Marketing Solutions**
  - Ran **needs analysis** with each client and prepared proposals with cost and impact estimates.
  - Won new B2B clients: **123% of lead target** and **50% conversion**.
- **Performance Reporting: E-Commerce Client Campaigns**
  - Analysed weekly **acquisition cost, conversion and channel mix** for each client.
  - Recommended **budget shifts** to the channels that converted best.

Freelance Business Analyst & International Travel · Jan 2025 – Present

- Researched **China market entry for a Japanese personal care maker**: category, channels, competitors, pricing.
- Travelled a year across **Europe, South America, the USA and Asia**; volunteered in **Colombia** (hostel bartender) and **Peru** (dog shelter) and **learned basic Spanish** in Bolivia.
- Relocated to Düsseldorf and reached **German B2 in 8 months** through intensive daily courses and self-study.

EDUCATION

- Master of Environment Science for SDGs, Hokkaido University, Sapporo, Japan | Apr 2017 – Mar 2019
- Bachelor of Environment Design for Landscape, Chengdu University, Sichuan, China | Apr 2011 – Mar 2015

LANGUAGES & INTERESTS

- English: Professional Working Proficiency (TOEIC 805 · 2021 | negotiation-level business use)
- Japanese: Professional Working Proficiency (JLPT N1 · 2017 | 5+ years working experience)
- Chinese (Mandarin): Native
- German: B2 (zertifiziert)
- Interests: reading, lifewriting, dancing, hiking, volunteering